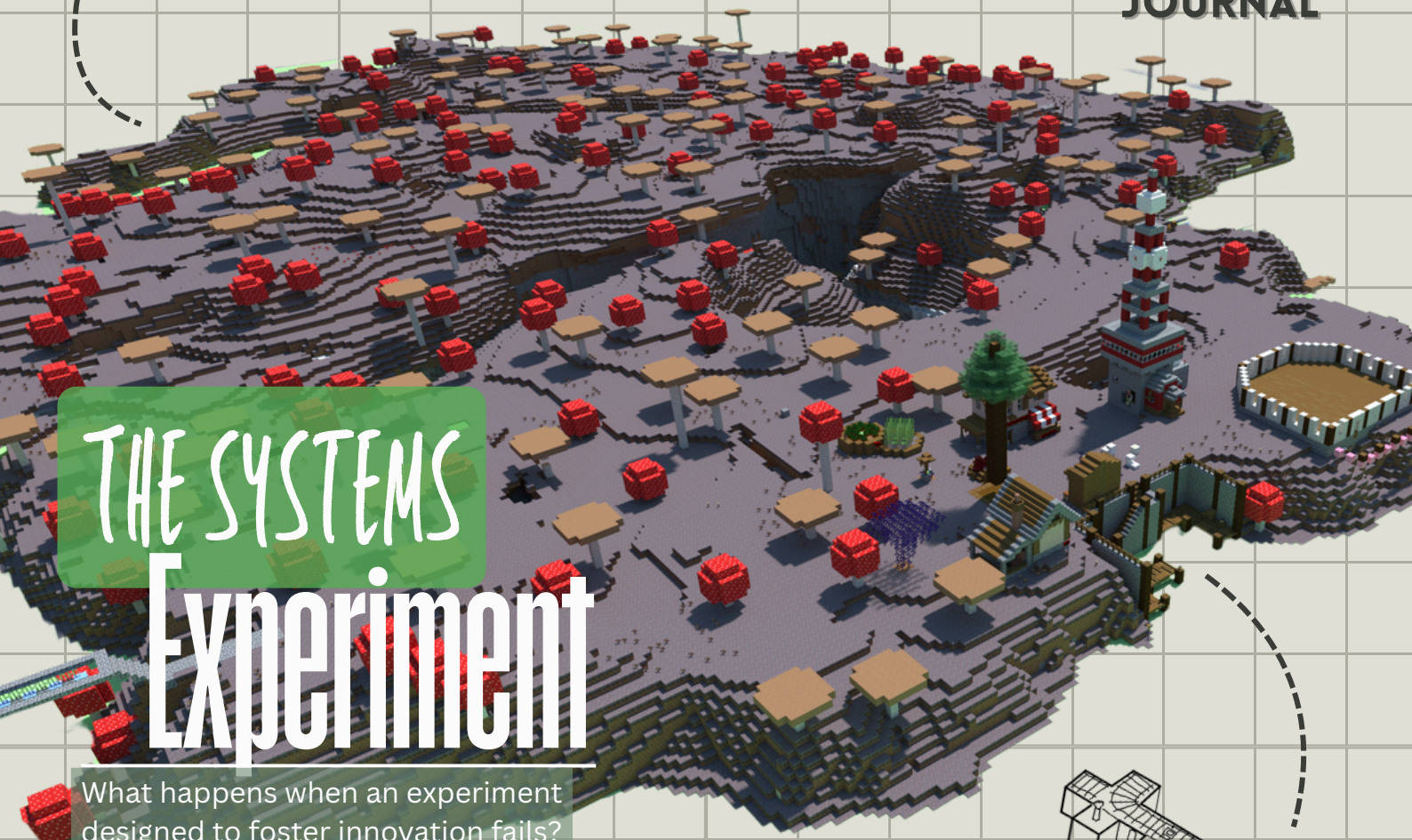
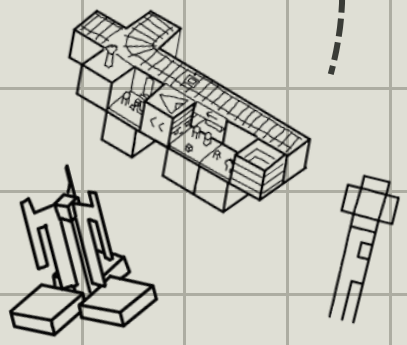
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THE INSTITUTE OF MINECRAFT STUDIES JOURNAL



THE SYSTEMS Experiment

What happens when an experiment designed to foster innovation fails? *The Systems Experiment* tracks the fallout of a small population strained by outsized problems, and explores the true blueprint of civilization.



The Ordonian Calculus and the IMS - p.2

Stewardship, Agency, and the Economy of Information in The Systems Experiment

Political Philosophy Is Useless for the Study of Servers - p.23

Political philosophy can only engage in a descriptive, not normative, role in the study of communities.

Society and Governance Parallels in Minecraft - p.18

Making predictions about the future by drawing parallels with the real world

The removal of agency by server owners and reclaiming player power - p.31

A structure where players remove the need for an owner and establish a server where decisions are made by players

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Editors: Harlow, retrooper

Journal coordinator: koviubi

Editor-in-chief: matcha_tea (before October 26), koviubi (after October 26)

Note from the Journal coordinator

During the past few months, our Department has gone through some major changes. The Institute elected Editor-in-chief matcha_tea, who asked me to lead the project of adopting our Constitution. In an effort to professionalize and formalize our Department's work, we have established our policies and have written useful step-by-step guides for all roles throughout the writing, reviewing, and editing stages. We have also rebranded as the *Institute of Minecraft Studies Publishing Department* to better reflect what we focus on.

I would like to personally thank everyone who has helped throughout this process. Going forward, we plan to publish a new issue of this Journal every three months. We ask anyone who is interested to come join us and help the Department thrive: whether it is through writing news articles, opinion pieces, or formal theories; performing research or experiments; or editing others' works. We are always welcoming new reporters, columnists, and editors into our Department, and we provide mentoring to new members so that they can get started more easily. Even a couple of hours a week can help us tremendously. Don't worry; you can change your mind anytime. If you would like to try this out, give it a shot!

—koviubi, Journal coordinator

Article 1

The Ordonian Calculus and the IMS: Stewardship, Agency, and the Economy of Information in The Systems Experiment

Author: Llamangus. Editor: Harlow. Peer reviewed.

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Abstract

Agency and Stewardship theories can be used to describe how we understand the relationship between delegates and delegators, both in the corporate world, in volunteer spaces, and in The Systems Event. We can understand how the lack of a clear framework, compounding issues from the organization of the event, and player siloing worked against the desired goals of the event. This essay draws on first-hand experiences and accounts from related essays, tracing how two competing teams diverged and were impacted during the events Exploration and Exploitation time frame, largely from the Ordonian perspective. "The Ordonian Calculus" is posed as a phenomenological analysis of social and systemic risks and anticipations, and their effects on team cohesion.

The essay also proposes an Agency Theory of Minecraft, arguing that the default singleplayer design leaves multiplayer environments particularly exposed to agentic, exploitative play absent of deliberate design intervention, and offers guidance for future IMS events.

1.1 Introduction

We were down to 'the core four', the burnt-out remnants of the presidium by the third week of The Systems Experiment (TSE): Pheelix('Zandercamper'), Blaze ('blAze_floW'), Tiff ('Emo_Cupcakes'), and myself – Llamangus ('ComradeLlamangus'). The Presidium was Pheelix's design, intended to be a temporary structure for the earliest days of the two-month long exploitation period.[a] It was less than halfway there when even the core four began to log in less and less.

Along with designing the presidium, Pheelix created the Discord and test server, and was the proactive leader that Ordonia needed in the exploration phase.[b] Blaze created a detailed, towering city design with towers and aqueducts. Tiff, perhaps our most active player, created most of the farms we could theoretically need for our systems.

Ultimately, we discovered a lot of our systems were overbuilt for the conditions we found ourselves in, as we were prepared for a team of ten to twenty. The Ordonian government never reached its potential, the city planning was slow and inflexible, and there wasn't much of an economy to build around.

I addressed the presidium in the #leadership-private section of our Discord as there were things that needed to be said. The event had not gone as planned, and there was no reason to expect that conditions of the event would change to meet the needs of our designs. We each had to pick up increasing amounts of responsibilities as most of our team had either been no-shows on the server or had dropped out. None of the core four wanted to be seen as the group's failure point, but each of us at one point or another in the event had taken on large tasks. In Rev's work titled 'Who Decides? Leadership, Legitimacy, and Load in competing teams', he pointed out during interviews that members' perception of the shared workload differed fairly dramatically, depending on what systems they were in charge of. (Rev, 2026)

It seemed like the only option was to reorganize, learn to communicate more effectively, and reassess our goals in this event. By this point even the organizers knew this event would not produce the desired outcomes. However, even 'bad' Minecraft, like pizza, is still 'good Minecraft'.

The next day, Turtle announced that the event would end and be turned into an SMP with the opening of the End and the dragon fight the following week, but even the SMP would shut down for good less than a week later as the Institute shifted its focus for August. It was a relief that it was allowed to end on a good note.

In light of the failures of the Systems Experiment, guidelines need to be set in place by the IMS in order to clear the ambiguity of players, the IMS needs to understand what resources they have as far as players and players time, and Agency and Stewardship[c]

[a] Or *Exploitation phase* in the first Systems Event. The execution and implementation of systems and the realization of their value within the existing structures and bodies of knowledge.

[b] Or *Exploration phase* in the first Systems Event. The generation of novel assumptions and ideas to be proven useful

[c] a model of behavior wherein an individual is not simply motivated by individualistic utility, but is instead a steward whose motives are aligned with those of the Principal and/or collective, even when those interests may diverge

should be adopted as a framework for understanding the social underpinnings of servers, especially in regard to leadership due to the similarities between server event planning and a business.

1.2 The setup

According to early promotional materials for the event, it is described as a team-based event where players are individually tasked with designing a system: "A repeatable structure of Rules, Incentives, or infrastructure." These systems would need to fit one or more of the categories listed: Economic, Government, Society, Infrastructure, Incentive, Industry, or Defense. Players had roughly three weeks through the month of June to submit a systems draft of their idea for the event, with late comers given a grace period.

In Rev's article on the Systems Experiment, he describes the event in two phases: "Exploration" and "Exploitation". (Rev, 2026) The promotional material calls this Exploration phase the 'preseason'. This work will continue using Rev's reference.

During the event's Exploration phase, players were free to ask questions about how the event would be run. These questions were primarily answered by Turtle, the creator of TSE. One of the questions from 'Dinosawrr' (dino.sawrr), as paraphrased by Turtle, asked, "can outside, non-systems players join as citizens?" (Turtle, 2026a) Turtle's response gives us some insight into his thought process as an event organizer, stating, "no, people cannot join without following the normal requirements and expectations". (Turtle, 2026a) He goes on to explain:

> While it sounds fine in theory, this will introduce a lot of members who want to focus specifically on SMP style play. They are likely to get annoyed with systems over time and bypass them. In addition, we want systems to use each other (i.e., industry system player sells goods to infrastructure player with a currency from an economic system player), which might be diluted by non systems players.
>
> I believe it is entirely possible to design the systems you want without non systems players, and I think we should think about it more like a cross between Hermitcraft and Ish civ than just a civ. You people will have more time than the average team, you will be closer, and you will design systems that are more intricate. Besides, Minecraft is, as we have seen, a very easy game for single/low player counts. (Turtle, 2026a)

This shows that Turtle had some foresight into the problems that The Systems Event could, and in fact, did run into. From a first glance, it's clear that Turtle and the organizers at the IMS wanted this event to produce a certain kind of outcome. The Systems 'not an experiment' Experiment was created to develop and showcase emergent systems. These systems would be developed competitively by two teams, Alpha and Beta (Beta would later be renamed to Ordonia).

Two examples were loosely cited as inspiration for this event. Civilization Event servers, with a clear factional focus, large and equally distributed player base, and sessioned play. The IMS, should they choose something like this, must consider these requirements in advance of team formation. These kinds of events are well known to many in the IMS, with members who have watched or participated in these kinds of events.

The second example was Hermitcraft. It may not be realistic for the IMS to host events that resemble Hermitcraft per se, but there could be an organizational philosophy based on that model, except for a structure suitable for our experiments and events. This assumes that stewardship is valued over agentic gameplay,[a] meaning that robust systems, narratives, and shared lore are created with each member potentially being a force-multiplier for each other. In a server, this might mean looser teams, districts, and less focus on 'social victories'. This doesn't mean an end to team-based competitions entirely, but it could be of a smaller scope inside another event, department, or SMP.

The setup was meant to be in a fairly 'archaic' or 'vanilla' environment, without much attention to balanced gameplay with the exception of the banning of End Crystals and Elytras. (Turtle, 2026b,c) There were few mods on the server, but we did use Simple Voice Chat and a 'Wiretap' mod that provided a speaker and receiver. There was also a mod for copper rails; however, it did not have a large effect on gameplay, and its presence went largely unnoticed, only being used by Team Alpha between their settlement and their ice boat path to the shared neutral mushroom island.

Turtle had found a seed that at a first glance seemed to be perfect for this event. Team Alpha was given the seed a day earlier to pick between the northern or southern continent – an advantage that the organizers gave as a concession due to Alpha's difficulty recruiting and keeping active members up to that point. Alpha picked the northern continent, which had the only Pale Garden biome and the only ancient city that was found. Ordonia was given the southern continent, which had the largest Badlands and Mangrove Swamp Biomes. Ordonia's location would prove useful later for the Nether, being right next to a Fortress and being the closest to the only Bastion we would get in this event.

1.3 Good intentions, flawed design

We had a month to draft our systems and work with our teams to refine and plan their implementation. This 'exploration phase' was quite generous on time, with the hopes that enough people would have drafted and refined the systems they would use in the exploitation phase. A 'near-vanilla' experience, with few guidelines or restrictions beyond the siloing[b] was intended to allow more emergent systems to be developed.

[a] Gameplay that optimizes for maximal utility of its systems as permitted by the game itself or playing as if crossing off a checklist. "Given the opportunity, players will optimize the fun out of a game." A player engaged in Agentic Gameplay defaults to Exploitation of known-optimal strategies towards a model of complete-ness, often over the game's fuller possibility space. This mirrors the Agents pursuit of individual utility over the Principal or collective's broader interests.

[b] Sorting of players into teams, often for competitive or antagonistic purposes. Encouraging agentic playstyles and rationale for the benefit of teams. (Factions, Nations, Clans, etc.)

Siloing the player base into teams is a common approach in competitive PvP events; however, those team are usually balanced in number, large enough to support the logistical needs of the team, players understand the focus of the event before they go in, and the victory conditions are often congruent with this scheme. This mismatch in focus on top of the 'vanilla' or 'archaic' framing of the event produced a bifurcation of focus among a small and uneven player base.

We can see how choices in the design and execution of The Server Experiment cumulatively might have led to the ending previously described. In "The Consequences of Poor Design" by Harlow, one of the fundamental issues posed was the lack of clear communication which led to uncertainty and burnout among sections of the player base. (Harlow, 2026) The problem of poor communication is not the sole or original critical flaw of the event, but it had several down-stream effects. We should ask: why was communication here poor?

The Systems Event was meant to develop systems that are the most broadly applicable or replicable inside of many types of servers; when we think of 'vanilla', 'archaic', or 'anarchic' types of environments, where little gets in the way of player agency, we are mostly adapting to the structural systems given to us by Mojang. The event also created structural particularities that detracted from its focus. Given its siloed team-based nature and the a priori creation of levels of secrecy, the experiment became less about the face-value goals and more of an impromptu analysis of leadership and player sociology. By implying formal barriers, TSE organization made a choice that produced civ-like narratives over Hermitcraft-like emergent collaborative systems.

Hermitcraft is a model for a server of systems-creators in an otherwise mostly vanilla environment (data and resource packs aside). Each new member has been vetted after being known by their members for a while. A series might last between one to two years. An emergent system might take anywhere from a weekend to several months. The key difference is that hermits are not usually siloed. Each hermit is in some respects a force multiplier for each other.

1.4 Through a lens of Agency and Stewardship

In the world of business and finance, there is Agent theory and Stewardship theory. Agency, the more dominant theory, defines formal collaborative relationships between Principals[a] and Agents.[b] The Principals delegate to Agents. It is in the best interests of Principals to create control schemes to minimize their risk of mismatched interests between parties. This poses a prisoner's dilemma between Principal and Agent, where cooperation is put up against individualistic utility maximization. This is in contrast to Stewardship models, which attempts to refute the pessimistic, control-oriented Agency

[a] In business, the Principal is the shareholders who appoint executives as managers of a business/organization. In TSE, both the organizing body and the teams act as Principals over the players.

[b] a utility-maximizing subordinate in a business relationship

framework. Instead, 'agent' gets re-framed as 'manager'.[a] Psychologists and sociologists criticize Agency Theory[b] as having an incomplete understanding of organizational life and motivations. So, the question is: What causes interests to be aligned? (Davis, 1997)

The corporate-legal environment, of course, is very different from the Institute of Minecraft Studies or the Systems Experiment. Unlike a shareholder-executive relationship, no capital or legal obligations bind Principals and Agents. What I am offering by borrowing this frame is a method of analysis of server or event life. What Stewardship and Agency describe here is the uncertainty of the motives of both delegates and delegators, and how that uncertainty shapes anticipation and control-seeking behavior. This uncertainty exists whether the currency is dividends or the credibility of systems. Furthermore, you could extend the corporate examples to something closer to our world. Volunteer or open-source governance more broadly shows Agency and Stewardship theories into non-contractual settings; the IMS already does this through implementing a shared mission and democratic modes of leadership in departments. Understanding these relationships within servers and the IMS broadly could help us understand what is needed to shape and reinforce the intrinsic motivation that we rely on.

This, of course, brings us back to the IMS and the event. The IMS is a decentralized organization of volunteers and collaborators. Turtle and the IMS are the originating Principal from which a stewardship-oriented culture has naturally arrived. This Principal relationship also comes as a form of what Rev (2026) calls "homophily".

While Turtle's response to Dinosawrr's question was eventually overturned due to a lack of active players near the July 1st launch of the server (Exploitation Phase), we can establish the cultural practice of Stewardship are, stated or not, within the focus of this event, particularly with its relationship to the IMS. Seetloveletter, a member of the IMS Discord server who has extensive experience with Civ-style events and SMPs, stated as such that the typical IMS member would not be representative of the typical Civ event roster. (seetite, 2026)

Despite Turtle's criticism of 'Content SMPs' or 'Scripted SMPs' – noting that the events and player archetypes are made to appeal to a consumer outside of said SMPs – it is still the case with events that the agents or managers could be described as serving two principals, and a calculus of sorts had arrived to bridge the gaps where there were mismatched goals and understandings. (Turtle, 2026, nd)

1.5 Formative consequences

> Scorvon: "Ordaina [sic] had a whole city built, banks schools etc, one week later they were bombed and everything was destoryed [sic];" "you cant win if ur systems are gone". (scorevon, 2026a,b)

[a] In business, the individual(s) entrusted to execute the Principals objectives. May behave either as a self-serving Agent, or collective serving steward, depending on situational and psychological factors. In Minecraft, a player is a manager of oneself and the environment.

[b] In business, control schemes must be used to reduce the risks posed by conflicting interests between Principals and Agents.

blAze_floW: “And your victory will be empty if we never finish our systems in the first place” (blazeflow, 2026)

Scorvon: “[a] win’s a win” (scorevon, 2026c)

A lack of proper communication and foresight given towards the principles of this event caused a conflict of interest in how participants saw the purpose of the event. For some, it was meant to be a sportsmanly development of systems, or a casual laboratory under the eyes of the shared Principal of the IMS. For others, the most obvious approach was more of a binary.

This split likely formed because of the differences in how the teams form through the course of the exploration and early exploitation phases. Ordonia had the full extent of time and the active support of early members of the presidium, particularly with Pheelix and Blaze. We had two large systems meant to encompass Ordonian life well before the server actually opened, meant to be the all-stars of the competition. We believed we were well prepared and advantaged during a time when Alpha was seen, as Turtle put it, ‘The Resistance’.

This framing seemed to hold even as membership requirements loosened to drive recruitment. I invited a friend of mine to the event; through which either by neglect or the organizers’ providence, was assigned to Team Alpha. Ordonia had a spy in Alpha’s ranks!

Alpha, on the other hand, rose through likely because their conditions favored a different approach. Their leadership was more centralized under a figurehead like Scorvon than later Phantom_Boi, but their society was considerably less centralized. There were no democratic presidium or secretaries appointed via assembly as Pheelix had in mind for Ordonia.

Where Ordonia was waiting for a city design suitable enough, orderly enough, aesthetically harmonic enough, or complete enough in its design – Alpha’s decentralized approach benefited their city. They had detailed builds, bases, social spaces like a tea party garden and a colosseum. Ordonia had a collection of cabin-like builds among farms; an industrial district posing as a town, supporting 4 players hoping that somehow new life would be put into the server by some manner, while we deliberated systems that were dreamt up before the server opened.

Alpha’s approach came with some drawbacks though. There were complaints about the casual and careless use of wind charges, the death of all but one armadillo in an XP farm that was built out in the open. To us, there seemed to be a lack of cohesion among members of Alpha. A couple members confided that they were considering building away from their town. There was a similar sentiment in Ordonia before any headway was made on the city.

While Ordonia was building up its industry, Alpha crossed off a lot of the usual accomplishments before finishing the colosseum. They exhausted the trial chambers on their side and asked us for the right to use trial chambers on our side. They completed their colosseum and practiced PvP. But eventually their team would be largely inactive, except for the day of the Nether expansion and the Ender Dragon fight.

1.6 Formation of a calculus

There were signs at the server launch that The Systems Experiment had started off wrong. There wasn't much of an official launch. Some Ordonians weren't even aware when it launched. We were set into spectator mode to explore a map in which unbeknownst to us had a smaller world border than we had planned for, until we were able to convince Turtle to open the map up to its full intended extent. Later, most of the Ordonians that would be active were set to survival mode on the correct side of the map, but Team Alpha would continue to face issues with being in spectator or adventure mode until the next day. Some even spawned or respawned suffocating underground.

1.6.1 A matter of principals

Naturally, Team Alpha was quite upset about this. Ordonians took a stewardship approach out of concern that the event couldn't survive without two active teams. We gathered food, iron, blocks, and saplings from our collection to help them, then sailed to a small dock they called the embassy. It didn't take them long to recover. Their team quickly grew to a size of around six to eight active members compared to our core four, one of which was unable to participate for the second week. Some of us questioned if giving them the care package was a wise idea, stating that it removed from them a lot of necessary work and travel to get some of those supplies, and at our own expense. We were able to help them 'cross things off a checklist'. Thus, we can see a conflict between two instincts and two principals emerge. Do we do what seems best for the event, or do we serve only the interests of our team? This is the first part of the Ordonian Calculus.[a]

This point is also echoed in Harlow's 'The Consequences of Poor Design', where it was noted that the typical Minecraft player, one that is not from the IMS, would be more concerned with getting ahead rather than the "idealistic purism" of "a niche online community, [like the IMS]". (Harlow, 2026) It can also be seen how the divergence in development over time alongside homophily within the IMS led to diverging subtextual readings about the bounds and priorities of the event.

Ordonia has had a longer, more thorough period of exploration, even while both teams had the same time window. Ordonia grew during the exploration phase, causing Pheelix to take leadership much more seriously to handle the increasing player base. One that did not materialize as expected during the exploitation phase. We also had members that were active in the IMS broadly, one of which would eventually take the reins of the systems experiment from Turtle later on.

Alpha benefited from a rush of recruitment and a relaxation of requirements to participate in the event after a serious lag in recruitment and activity for most of the exploration phase. They had less formal ground to work with and some of their active members applied a different subtext to the event, one that would otherwise serve them in a typical factions-based SMP.

[a]Social and systemic anticipation during The Systems Event by the individual members. Risk and failure model assessments unique to members of Ordonia.

To lay out the principals, the primary principal is the IMS which includes the organizers of TSE. The other Principal is whichever team the player is on. These principals would presumptively work against each other because of what was left to subtext. Ordonia's core four were in a high demand, low information environment with its members sharing more responsibility and losing interest.

Alpha didn't carry the weight of planning or fulfilling large systems in quite the same sense. The way that Alpha formed by the opening of the server led to a team that was primarily focusing on the most legible aspects of the event, with the formal focuses typically left to whoever was the leader at the time.

The differences in styles of leadership would prove consequential in the way members – stakeholders in their respective teams – related to power and team organization. Power and Legitimacy was established with roles and elections during the exploration phase in Ordonia. Alpha held an election quite some time after the opening of the server. Alpha did not perceive a need for formal elected roles beyond the sole leadership.

1.6.2 Diplomacy

Scorvon is a player whose history and perspectives were sadly missing from Revs 'Who Decides?' paper. His role as the leader of Team Alpha was as iconic as the power struggle between him and Phantom_Boi, who eventually beat him in Alpha's election. He was a 'strongman' of sorts, and an extremely effective leader who saw Alpha's swift early progression.

A member of Ordonia intercepted a written book on the mushroom island pertaining to Scorvon's leadership and the talks of war. The journal states that war was likely to take place for 'entertainment value'. They were aware of the mismatched team size, and the presence of fully geared PvPers on their team. They wanted to declare when all Ordonians were active. This would conflict with statements from both Scorvon and Phantom_boi that the majority of team Alpha did not want war. The journal confirms this later by stating that many in team Alpha were skeptical about Scorvon, leading to Phantom_Bois' victory. In Revs' interviews, Rev was led to believe that there were no power struggles in Alpha, and Scorvon was not mentioned in the manuscript as of this moment. (Rev, 2026)

We became more deliberate in our interactions with Team Alpha, and observed patterns in the way they organized, kept the condition of their town, and tended to coordinate in small sub-groups or as individuals. There were complaints from Alphas that critical pieces of information, such as the state of treaties, weren't communicated well or at all. There was confusion about whether the majority of Team Alpha wanted war or wanted to avoid war. The most active members were looking for war and often conducted espionage even after we've come to agreements about what we expect before anyone comes to the opposite team's land. The easiest 'catch' was when they required assistance getting out of our blocked Nether portals, a measure we took after one of us was killed in the Nether.

However, it wasn't always quite hostile, thanks to Hilo's efforts with the Tea Parties and her work on the mushroom island. There were also trade arrangements as Alpha

was in need of a lot of building materials, and they had the only Pale Garden biome on the map. In order to get the few resin clumps they had, we needed to be transparent in why we wanted resin. The biggest point of the resin trade for Ordonia was to gather information. We were 'anti-monopoly', and this incident would give us clues into how Alpha operates. Resin and its related products had its uses, but was never critically important. Nonetheless it was a monopoly and a somewhat strategic one. The early-game question was what their behavior would be towards more strategic monopolies – like the nether expansion granting either team access to the Netherite Upgrade Template.

Despite the trades and agreements, trust was still uneasy. While individuals within team Alpha had their own reputation, we were still cautious dealing with any member of Team Alpha. We would make sure that Ordonia wasn't deprived of the template by creating a rail line hidden low in the nether, covered to be less conspicuous where it crossed rivers and lakes of lava. We suspected a couple of their members killed an Ordonian they assumed had the template, but it was in an ender-chest.

1.7 Agentic gameplay

Perhaps the instinct to dominate or grief isn't incidental to this setting, but rather is invited by it. Minecraft is primarily built as a singleplayer game. While it can be played multiplayer, it does not have its own mechanisms built into itself that meaningfully alter the gameplay or add reasons or mechanisms to compete or cooperate with others. The systems that vanilla Minecraft provides are maximally legible and exploitable. It is easy for any experienced player to reach the end game. Minecraft isn't alone in this though. For example, Paradox grand strategy games in singleplayer modes are often built to reward accumulation and expansion, to 'paint the map' is rewarded until your game becomes too boring or tedious to manage. Multiplayer lobbies often ban a list of metas or strategies. Expansion becomes negotiated among neighbors, and exploitation of your resources becomes the meta for multiplayer lobbies. Players move from a utilitarian and agentic style of play to one more oriented towards stewardship both internally and externally. This environment is still competitive, but it remains one bounded by rules and negotiations to the benefit of everyone in the lobby.

These kinds of multiplayer strategy sessions also invite not just a different set of extrinsic goals, but invite intrinsic ones as well. You're responding to a different environment that doesn't exist in singleplayer, your choices are going to be different, more intrinsic to what is happening between players than the meta of the game itself.

Minecraft is built differently because it does not structurally create channels of strategic behavior, yet all the same it is a singleplayer game, with a simple and appealing progression chain. Build a base, get diamonds, maybe villagers, go to the Nether, then beat the dragon. It is a binary checklist of things you either did or did not do, and to some that is part of the point of the game. The game doesn't prioritize taking a creative route, navigating roadblocks, sticking by your own principles, or anything beyond the binary checklist in any structural manner. It is a mostly blank slate devoid of expectations, and most players will be accustomed to this. This is Agentic Gameplay.

1.7.1 The exceptions

Hermitcraft is one example of a model of stewardship, even when storylines reflect agency or rivalries for part or whole of a series. Pranksters and Institutions like the Permit Office offer some antagonism to varying degrees; however, it is all within the bounded context that Hermitcraft provides. No players are put into silos for extended periods of time. Contradicting goals serve a creative and narrative-driven goal. One could imagine though that private back channels exist, where surprises are managed and boundaries are discussed. Agency itself is subsumed through stewardship.

In a Systems Event context, this could be intentionally replicated by 'Red Teaming'.[a] A system would be designed to be tested by another group that assumes an antagonistic role, then report their assessment. In cybersecurity, ethical hackers have the same skills and tools as malicious ones, but their goals are non-destructive. They operate with permission from the organization while following a code of conduct.

Hermitcraft and similar SMPs are quite systems oriented due to their long running seasons. Hermitcraft is composed of over twenty members, whose presence helps to multiply the efforts of the individual. There is no siloing of players.

Survival Multiplayer Servers that focus on PvP, particularly siloed events like the civilization events hosted by Ish, rely on balanced teams and legible, predetermined structured systems from the organizers. The Systems Event lacked the structural support for both systems and for PvP. Members of the TSE were left to their own subtextual understanding and failure modelling. For Ordonia, we largely lost sight of the goal as we were carrying a debt from our exploration phase that we had difficulty fulfilling, and we were managing more internal and diplomatic tasks.

1.7.2 The question of war

The question of war was something that wasn't fully clear for us. There wasn't much to go off of in official documentation of what war means, the stakes of war, the period, and should it be a bilateral or unilateral 'declaration'. Was war just another testing ground, or was it part of the aim of the event in itself, as opposing factions are prone to do?

Applications were supposedly screened against people who were 'too PvP focused', yet war wasn't taken off the table. It was another thing left for the 'vanilla' or 'archaic' feel – undefined and underbaked axioms that were counterproductive to the event. It was something you could do, if you want.

But the event couldn't support a war-based factional narrative. There was no hardcore mode, unbalanced starting conditions, and no guidelines for it. Early on, I suggested a 'gentleman's war' at the last week of the event. That plan didn't get very far, as activity dwindled after the second week. Admittedly, the idea of a unilaterally declared war was something that seemed out of place in this event to most Ordonians, largely because of the imbalance in teams and the subtext we have interpreted for the event.

[a] a term used in cybersecurity, where ethical hackers on the behalf of an organization act as antagonists, using the tools and exploits of real antagonists

We Ordonians were aware of, or at least told, that a sizable portion of Team Alpha was interested in war 'for entertainment value', and that some saw it as a valid zero-sum path towards victory by the metrics of The Systems Experiment. Individually, we went back and forth on how much we should interact with Alpha. Some members would be suspicious and then cool off, only for others to be similarly suspicious. While we felt that the people of team Alpha were fairly transparent actors, we couldn't always take what they said at face value.

1.7.3 The temperature of the tea

Hilo's role in the event stood out as the host of tea parties early on, where potions were labelled as 'Osmanthus Tea'. She became one of the primary builders on the neutral mushroom island alongside Blaze. She was seen as a neutral party, yet still at least nominally a part of Alpha. We were aware that she was collecting information during the event, and that she had some connection with the Publishing Department.

We recognized that her positions towards both Principals were unique. When there was little reason for Ordonia to interact with Alpha, her tea parties were a diplomatic bridge that didn't need a formal excuse outside itself. It was an invitation to come to them, see what they have built and developed under diplomatic auspices.

Visitations slowly dropped off as a Visa system implemented by Scorvon came into effect. This was an early power-grab of his before the election. My first visa was signed by Phantom_Boi during their power struggle, only for Scorvon to declare it invalid and request that I fill out another visa. It didn't take long for most cross-team activity to switch to the mushroom island, bypassing the need to adhere to antisocial visa policies, the principle of which were sometimes violated in either direction anyway.

'Neutral' positioning aside, we all answered to a team, but we understood Hilo answered to the IMS and the publishing department in a way we weren't quite sure of yet. She adopted a stewardly position, but we wouldn't be sure of what that could have implied should she or the organizers wanted to take the event in a specific direction. It's understood that a need for cross-team proximity was a given, and that we didn't quite understand how the organizers planned things, or if they have had much planning at all. We largely predicted the potential of Team Alpha as Agents rather than stewards or co-managers.

If we were to view things from the agentic perspective, with war being 'entertainment', we couldn't realistically provide a satisfactory argument against that. If war was a binary checklist item without guidelines or expectations, the results would be predictably lopsided. So, it wasn't really about preventing war on its own merits, but making war potentially expensive. Hilo's early diplomatic approach made it easier for us to make connections, trade deals, and social reconnaissance on Team Alpha.

The diplomatic game became one of learning about the members of the other team, getting candid and one-on-one disclosures, and making trade deals. The problem with trade deals in this environment though is leverage; each team would desire to have some kind of leverage over the other, but leverage spent is leverage lost. The economy of

information proved more valuable than most commodities in this kind of agency-driven environment, where guidelines and resources were thin.

1.7.4 The fall-off

War wasn't prevented by diplomatic activity alone, but largely through inactivity. Ordonia's systems proved difficult to implement with the scale and resources we ended up with, our city planning ambitions were poorly planned and mismatched. Some Ordonians deliberately took a break from the server, while some simply found other things more interesting, and the ones that stood by burned out.

Alpha, from what we could see, accomplished what they felt they could. The last two weeks of the event were mostly quiet from their side, with exception of the Nether expansion and the opening of the End. There was never a moment when enough Ordonians would be on that declaring a war could be worthwhile.

1.8 Conclusion

We didn't manage to produce lasting systems that could be shown off, there was nothing guiding us towards novel cooperative approaches with so few members. There was little for either team to take back to the IMS, because in this type of loose, vanilla environment, the most interesting thing is what the other team is doing. Where The Systems Event may have been productive was as a study of inter- and intra-team dynamics, and as a lesson of how not to create events.

What could be done for future events depends on the direction that the IMS intends to take them. Turtle seems to have drawn inspiration from different sources while trying to design for the broadest appeal, but without more deliberate design, clear communication and intentions, and a proactive consideration for players' time, we may see a repeat of this season's turn out.

It might be more prudent to risk over-design of future events, so that each season carries with it an identity, a set of unique problems or challenges, or conditions imposed, such that the focus becomes player versus environment, or player within the temporary society. Vanilla doesn't always mean perfectly vanilla or without guidelines, and anarchy vanilla has a particularly short set of possible outcomes.

Through the lens of Agency and Stewardship, we may begin to understand how player behavior relates to the environment they find themselves in. Even when interests don't directly align, all parties should be aware of the interests of each other. The Systems Event was set up with Three Principal Entities all acting within their own interests while performing a mental calculus of each party's intentions and efficacy.

It is up to organizers and server administrators to understand and anticipate the resources at their disposal. The system drafts turned into mere homework. The asynchrony of development and implementation cooled motivation and led to systems misaligned with the actual conditions of exploitation. Failure to set and clearly communicate guidelines,

goals, and expectations created an environment of uncertainty that was counterproductive for the assumed goals of the event.

The design of the event did not clearly define its principles. We can somewhat surmise the intentions through the resources and statements that do exist; however, no true mission statement or theory of design has been made available outside of a points system. The structure of the event worked against both the resources it had available and its own design goals.

In conclusion, there should be a theory of Stewardship for the IMS. Any events, experiments, SMPs, or otherwise should have a clear scope and structure, with the understanding that emergent systems will develop downstream from structural systems. Minecraft itself is structural, 'vanilla', 'semi-vanilla', 'anarchy', etc., are not neutral choices, nor are all or most servers in a category going to be the same. These choices are structural and worthy of scrutiny.

Minecraft Server Theory is still young, but has a solid framework thanks to creators like Matcha_Tea, Turtlestate, KingGame, Pinecone, and others. We have only started on what will be a rich tradition for Minecraft as a platform. Player and staff/owner behavior and motivations are as, if not more, important than the systems themselves.

1.9 Acknowledgements

I would like to acknowledge Harlow for her initial feedback on the previous draft. This essay was difficult to write, but I hope it provides needed insight from a participant in the event. I would also like to acknowledge Rev's work and interviews as it provides an 'overhead' view of the event that is professional and fair to both teams. This essay might not have been finished without either of them.

I had anticipated writing this essay since the end of the second week, yet it has had several redrafts and reorganizations. It is currently two weeks after the closing of the event, but after reorganizations and assessments of bias I hope that this article is worthy of the IMS.

Lastly, I want to acknowledge Turtle and Harlow again for their role in organizing the event.

1.10 Declarations

The author has declared a conflict of interest due to being on the Ordonian team. No conflict of interest has been declared by the reviewer and editor. No AI use has been declared.

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Article 2

Society and Governance Parallels in Minecraft: The Systems Experiment Findings

Author: Mila. Editors: Harlow and retrooper. Peer reviewed.

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Abstract

The Minecraft world is an example of a digital space that closely resembles our real world. TSE specifically, just like many other multiplayer servers, is an ideal place to observe said similarities. By finding connections between both worlds involving phenomena such as how power is distributed, diplomacy handled, or how the world progresses, we can also use this information to make predictions about events involving those topics. This can be achieved through a simple process involving a little bit of history and logic.

2.1 The commons of different worlds

In a world where the internet bridges large distances and connects individuals throughout the globe, there are bound to be certain applications that will simulate the world itself. Games like Minecraft that allow players to gather and build cultures and governments represent this perfectly; however, many people fail to realize how similar a simple game can match our large and complex society. In the instance of the Systems Experiment server, a multiplayer Minecraft server with two opposing "countries", three particular topics stood out to strongly resemble their real-world counterparts. By gathering the perspectives of the majority of individuals per team and contrasting them with movements and popular opinions in the real-world, the resemblance between a Minecraft

society and our real-world societies is evident. By the end of the experiment, many players witnessed the same entropy that came with technology, as well as many diplomatic events that could only be synthesized by one's experiences in the real-world. With these parallels drawn, people can attempt to explain real-world phenomena, explore the causes of important events, and even make their own predictions about the world we live in. Although power is a highly debated topic, for the sake of this article, we can describe power as how capable a person is of changing the behaviors of a group of people. In our world, power is distributed and held in many different ways, with examples ranging from influencers on social media, to people with enough power to conceal themselves from public knowledge. One concentration of power, however, is visible in both TSE and real life—that being politicians. In real life, politicians obtain power through public support, control of resources, and by utilizing their ability to change government policy. To determine whether the leadership roles in the IMS experiment match those of politicians, we must draw connections between these aspects.

To start, within the experiment server, both teams required their leaders to hold a sufficient amount of support from their people. This can be particularly seen with Team Alpha's first election on July 11, 2026, where Phantom won over Scorvon in a poll. This was achieved partially in his speech, where his promises for stability and his anti-war emphasis reflected the concerns of the people, similar to real life campaigns. Actions also are involved, as some voters might have cast doubt on Scorvon's own pro-diplomatic claims after overhearing his threats toward Ordonia. Next, itistiff and Llama Amongus, in charge of Team Ordonia's relations with Team Alpha, were able to permit the allocation of resources to provide trade to team Alpha. We will soon see why they did this, but said trade still holds a considerable amount of diplomatic power, as its use (or lack of it) can determine friends, foes, or everything in between. In instances of changing government policy, leaders like Scorvon, Phantom, and Pheelix signed agreements espionage, trade, and etiquette. At its core, agreements like these limit or expand the freedoms of players/people for a key change – mutual benefit. This benefit can boost both teams in many ways, while strengthening the relationship between the leaders and the populations, which is also useful for diplomacy. With these connections made, we can safely conclude that there is at least one major similarity in powerholders between the real world and TSE, however, we can also speculate about several other sources of power between the two worlds.

An apparent pattern that occurs in almost any world is material wealth. Especially in games like Minecraft where "grinding" can be used to obtain resources, people often resort to obtaining a surplus of materials or currency to gain power. With the use of material, this power can come in different forms, whether that be militaristic power (hiring soldiers/buying gear) or political power (lobbying/handouts). Overall, since power (or its use of it) can be a major factor in deciding actions or consequences in both worlds, this will aid the connection between the two worlds as well as predictions regarding politics.

Although wars in Minecraft are by no means the same as those in real life, the similar effects of war (death, destruction, loss of materials) makes diplomacy strikingly similar in both worlds. For a base definition of diplomacy, we could say that countries use

communication, compromise, and peacebuilding to prevent conflicts and resolve incidents. Although partially kept secret in TSE, these same three tactics could be seen being used by the leaders of team Alpha, the leader of team Ordonia, and the diplomatic board of team Ordonia. To start, by interviewing a couple of members of Ordonia (who I will keep anonymous in this article), they have admitted to using trade deals to try and prevent Alpha from wanting a war. This is a good example of peacebuilding, and a popular real-world tactic known as appeasement. Similarly to countries utilizing appeasement, Ordonia simply did not have the manpower or the resources to compete with Alpha militaristically, leading them to resort to trade to prevent the war entirely. There were also instances of meetings where both teams communicated about trades, issues, and the war they were trying to prevent. These were rather popular, to the extent that Team Alpha built a meeting place in their town hall to host them. Notably, it was both large and decorated, either to impress Ordonian diplomats and any spectators, or to ensure safety and convenience when hosting a meeting. This also took place to a lesser extent in smaller visits like tea parties, which were not exactly diplomatic oriented, but still served as proper communication and as an opportunity to build relations between teams at a personal level, which cannot be easily achieved with deals or diplomatic visits.

There have also been instances of compromise taking place within these meetings, specifically about policies and agreements that the two teams have created and upheld throughout the server. A good example of this would be how team Ordonia compromised to let team Alpha enter their territory, on the condition that any Alpha players visiting would announce themselves and keep their locator bar on. In terms of this agreement, it was much less implemented as a way to avoid war than a simple courtesy for Team Alpha as a whole. Courtesies such as this compromise can greatly affect opinions and relations, so they occasionally will be performed to improve one's image instead of genuine goodwill. As the event starts to come to a close (as of writing this article), it appears that these methods of diplomacy have worked, as a war has not started, and there is not any motive or motivation to start one in the remaining time. This connection can also serve a good purpose, as being able to predict wars and fights will aid the understanding of the players and the server better.

As mentioned in the introduction of this article, there has been an observable entropy linked with in-game progression, which is similar to the side effects we see with technology advancement in the real-world. To understand this fully, we must first look at how our world was affected by technology. At the surface level, it has improved our lives – people can live comfortably in soft mattresses and fancy smart homes, with technological efficiency in almost every corner of the world. The hard, dirty jobs have been replaced by large machinery that can automate grueling tasks at the press of a button, and discoveries like flight and electricity have made accomplishments that our ancestors could not even dream of. This is comparable to advancements in Minecraft too, with the unlocking of new resources like netherite, improvements in farms such as trading halls, and new items such as elytras. The most obvious drawback to new technology and improvements is the improvement of war.

Wars can be fought with brutal efficiency, with machine guns consecutively killing hundreds of people, and bombs being dropped to raze cities in mere seconds. Again, the same exists in Minecraft. Maces and wind charges can deal damage that no other weapon can, and massive redstone machines can be sent through the map, blowing up everything in their way. To most, this would seem as an appropriate consequence for the progression of technology, however, there are still much darker consequences that little realize until it is too late.

2.2 Finding use in patterns

With the evolution of society, depression, and other mental health issues have been rapidly increasing. (Hidaka, 2012) People's lives have been watered down to 9-5 jobs, with the rest of people's time spent idly watching TV, playing games, or being on social media. (Malinsky, 2026) This too is present in Minecraft, particularly when people get bored and burn out in the later stages of a server, rather than in the start of a fresh server. After all, this mainly happens after there is nothing new to do, or when people lose motivation to continue playing. A part of this is that the same technology – that sought to improve lives and automate the game – strips the joy and risk out of simple adventures and daily activities. In this regard, machines like auto miners or raid farms automatically harvest resources rather than having the player earn them, making it a repetitive clicking session instead of a thrilling outing. People can also burn out from the work, as the bigger end-game projects can be the same repetitive grinding we see in real life jobs. Several players fell victim to this in TSE. For example, one player (who will remain anonymous) experienced burnout from trying to figure out late-game redstone. But at the end of the day, sometimes there are still simple pleasures. After all, there is nothing quite like having a simple cup of tea in Minecraft, or in real-life.

Now that several key connections have been established, they can be used to predict certain related aspects about both Minecraft and real-life. To perform this, simply start by viewing a scenario in a "cause and effect" sort of way. Although being a simplified process, if supplemented with the correct data, it can utilize the past to provide a result. The past, being a useful tool, can be used to see many human behavioral patterns. Human history particularly is also one of the largest and most accessible pasts, making it accessible and plentiful. For a hypothetical scenario, let's start with:

> Cause: Tensions are very high between team Alpha and team Ordonia Effect:
>
> ???

To fill in the effect, all we would need to do is ask ourselves "if two countries had high tensions, what would they do in real life?" Then, using our historical knowledge, or knowledge about the world in the present world, we can fill in:

> Cause: Tensions are very high between team Alpha and team Ordonia Effect:
>
> Both teams will attempt to use diplomacy to ease the tensions.

Obviously, we cannot be certain if this is accurate at face value. If the cause is more specific (e.g., motives, amounts of resources already, etc.), the effect will also be more specific, and with predictions, even if you had a surplus of data for your cause, you can never be 100% sure about your effect.

2.3 Conclusion

All in all, the connections we can draw between the world of TSE and the physical world and the subsequent predictions only mark the start of what we can achieve with pattern recognition and an observant eye. Looking closely, it's also not hard to see common themes like power, diplomacy, and technology in other player-driven games too. However, just remember that even the comforting, blocky landscape of Minecraft can still be strikingly similar to the outside world we all know.

2.4 Declarations

The author and the reviewer have declared a conflict of interest, having participated within The Systems Experiment. The editor Harlow has declared a conflict of interest, having played and organized The Systems Experiment. No conflict of interest has been declared by the editor retrooper. No AI use has been declared.

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Article 3

Political Philosophy Is Useless for the Study of Servers

Author: Moldypizzar0ll. Editor: retrooper. Single-blind peer reviewed.

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Abstract

Players of sandbox games in virtual worlds are often inclined to think that the same social phenomena that spring up in real life are applicable to player-to-player interactions in game; further, that these interactions are often governed by broader moral or ethical principles that reflect those of the real world. Thus, for many it makes sense to apply political philosophy to these games, since they appear to give us a window into how these systems spring up in the real world. Minecraft is perhaps the clearest example; because of its open-ended structure, players consider it to be an ideal environment for simulating and theorizing about political communities. However, I will argue that insofar as Minecraft presupposes ideal conditions which players must then constrain themselves, political philosophy can only engage in a descriptive, not normative, role in the study of communities on Minecraft servers.

3.1 Introduction

Minecraft servers are interesting in myriad ways, not least due to the fact that we tend to think that they provide insights into how people behave under peculiar circumstances. Insofar as we think this to be the case, we are also tempted to make prescriptions for how those people *ought* to behave. To engage in a community is not just to engage in a descriptive project, in which the practices of the community are described and represented in detail, but also to engage in a normative one in which a certain level of institutional development and social coherence is needed to ensure that things are in order within

the community. Surely there would be few who would say that these assumptions are unreasonable; and from them we may be tempted to derive the notion that our ways of understanding what prescriptions we are beholden to in the real world, especially those that pertain to the political sphere, may also apply to communities broadly; Minecraft servers being no exception. Hence, our tendency to apply political philosophy to virtual worlds.

I will argue here, however, that many of these intuitions are mistaken; that, in fact, most of the questions with which political philosophy deals are scarcely of importance for understanding what goes on in Minecraft servers (though the case may be made for other games, I will limit the scope of this argument to Minecraft). In essence, political philosophy aims to generate normative prescriptions that apply to political societies, i.e., prescriptions that apply both to authorities (if one believes the set of legitimate authorities to be nonempty), and to people following those authorities. These prescriptions are motivated by real-world constraints, while communities in Minecraft are not so constrained; the place of political philosophy in Minecraft is thus *posterior*, rather than *anterior*, to what people ought to do; for political philosophy usually only serves to present what is possible to the players in terms of the kind of situation they would like to find themselves in rather than as a legitimate, normatively-binding force that acts upon them. Whatever normatively binding forces actually exist, exist on the level of *individuals* rather than on the level of a political community.

3.2 The purview of political philosophy

3.2.1 Resource distribution

In the first place, much of political philosophy is centered around how to distribute resources fairly. There are competing views, even prior to strictly political ones, as to how adequate distributions are to be achieved. Pure egalitarians argue that resources should be distributed equally across the population without exception. Luck egalitarians argue much the same and hold that differences in outcomes across individuals should be a function only of any given individual's own choices. Prioritarians argue that benefits given to the least well-off should be weighed more than those given to those better-off. (Parfit, 1997) There are, of course, different ethical theories that provide justification for various political theories. The prioritarian, for example, may be motivated by the utilitarian consideration that one should aim to maximize the amount of good done for the greatest number of individuals, which means giving benefits to the least well-off. Others may not be moved by utilitarianism and instead view the consequences of an action simply as a reason, yet not a *final* reason for doing something. In Anscombe's example, (Anscombe, 1967) five people are stranded on one island and one person on another; you manage to spot both islands and decide to save the one person. The five people, according to Anscombe, do not have a claim to having been *wronged*; for someone was indeed saved, and the rescuer did not decide *not* to save anyone. She discusses another example, more explicitly related to the distribution of resources. One

person suffers from a fatal illness, and a group of five suffer from the same illness. A single vial of an antidote is available; except the former person requires the entire vial to be cured, and the latter five each require one-fifth of the vial to be cured. No-one is wronged, Anscombe concludes, if one decides to give the one person the entire vial rather than saving the five. Is this a fair use of resources? Now, political considerations are, at bottom, ethical considerations. But there is disagreement with respect to how one moves from the ethical to the political. A plausible answer is that the ethical becomes the political when resources are involved on a sufficient scale—viz., when certain patterns of distribution may be considered more just than others. Whatever normative prescriptions follow, then, aim to achieve such distributions.

What we should note at this point is not strictly anything having to do with the individual views given here. Rather, we should note that the central aim of ethics is to remedy an existing state of affairs, call this A, via some theory so as to achieve a fairer, more just state of affairs; call this B. Different views have different verdicts on how to get from A to B, and what B would actually look like. Some, such as Anscombe, do not believe B to be wholly determined by the consequences of actions, and thus does not necessarily prescribe that B, for a good ethical theory, always supervenes on consequences. Others, such as Parfit, would disagree. (Parfit, 1984) One of the plausible, though perhaps not exhaustive, ways in which a view can conceive this move from mere ethical prescriptions to talk of the political (taken in the philosophical sense) is in terms of the distribution of resources.

In Minecraft servers, however, things work differently. Assuming we examine a vanilla server in its infancy, its initial conditions are starkly different than any "initial" state of affairs in the real-world. Players are hidden behind a Rawlsian "veil of ignorance", in which their physical real-world characteristics are largely stripped away and only their in-game capabilities and knowledge remain.[a] (Rawls, 1971, p. 10) The distribution of resources, moreover, is nominally equal. The Rawlsian metaphor here breaks down, as we cannot benefit the least well-off having assumed the veil of ignorance if the distribution of resources past a certain point is scarcely of importance. Of course, there may exist a scarcity of *labor*;[b] but there is little one cannot acquire with reasonable effort. Others have noticed this feature of the game, and many agree that the player is almost completely autonomous resource-wise. What are the possibilities, then, if one wants to make a server interesting? The traditional problems that drop out from the assumptions of real-world political philosophy do not really drop out in the case of Minecraft. Theoretically, each player can act autonomously resource-wise, and questions concerning how to distribute resources fairly do not arise. We are missing, however, the fact that this is precisely why political philosophy does not have any *normative* pull in Minecraft, at least in the case of resource distribution. For the good server owner knows that an effective way to motivate interest in a server is to *create* problems. The server owner may place

[a] Of course, their mental capacities, memories, previous relationships, etc., still remain. What matters is that each player has the capacity to affect and derive resources from the world similarly, which is not so in the real world.

[b] I'm indebted to Snorka for this observation.

borders on the world so as to limit the number of resources available; cap the number of valuable items in circulation; limit movement within a region to force cooperation; etc. It is only here that the traditional problems pop out. Indeed, if, for example, the world border is limited, one has to figure out the ideal distribution. But because such artificial constraints can only be generated by presupposing what the ideal distribution actually is (i.e., something like a server's unaltered state where players are completely resource-autonomous), the solution is already baked into the design. While real-world political philosophy is indeterminate as to what the ideal state of affairs (B) would look like from the perspective of a determinate state of affairs (A), a Minecraft server has to *create* indeterminacy by presupposing what the ideal conditions are and subsequently imposing constraints. Political philosophy, then, is only useful for people invested in the server insofar as the ones in charge of the server use it to *design* the server, rather than provide normative prescriptions for those within it. At that point, however, it ceases being political philosophy.

Political philosophy gets its normativity precisely because the state of affairs towards which it aims is indeterminate and hazy. We *ought* to do X in part because the possibility of X coming about is a *possibility*, not an actuality. We cannot say that one *ought* to do something given that the state of affairs with which they are charged with realizing has already come about.[a] In server design, by contrast, the tools political philosophy has at its disposal can only be cashed out in terms of *descriptions*. When the server owner imposes a world border, given what we know about what is valuable in the game, what the players ought to do is a foregone conclusion. We can only observe them going through the motions of playing within the world, knowing what the optimal decision procedures are for them already given the constraints. Now, the claim is not that the players are completely predictable; of course, players often do things they ought not to do (e.g., killing other players, griefing, hoarding, etc.), but that is not what is at stake here. The claim is that normative prescriptions cease being interesting as the *raison d'etre* of a community when the structures that organize that community already presuppose what people ought to do in the first place. Political philosophy in this case becomes an *explanation* for a state of affairs, rather than a guide for action so as to reach a different state of affairs.

3.2.2 The state

Take another salient topic in political philosophy: namely, the ideal position and configuration of the state. This is an issue with a distinguished history; its first true treatments may be found in Plato and Aristotle. The former thought the ideal form of political organization to consist of philosopher-rulers who, having been trained to seek truth and inquire into the nature of things (via the Forms), would be the best suited to manage a polity. (Plato, 1968) The latter (who was not terribly keen on the Forms) was concerned

[a] N.B. This is distinct from normative prescriptions which say that one ought to *repeat* certain actions so as to bring a certain state of affairs about continuously (e.g., continuously donating one tenth of your wealth to charity). The claim here pertains only to past states of affairs, which cannot be altered.

with the structure and size of the state as much as he was with what it ought to do. Should we have a monarch, in which only one individual rules, an aristocracy in which only a few rule, or a constitution[a] in which the majority rule? Aristotle (2008) thought a benevolent king to be the most ideal, though a constitution to be the most practical and just. Others were concerned with the function and limits of the state. Should the state wield unlimited power, or should it have checks and balances? Should we accept the latter, what kinds of checks should we impose? Hobbes was willing to accept the former; (Hobbes, 1994) others like Montesquieu and Nozick the latter. Sovereignty may be something that, by virtue of its nature, is indivisible—where any division in the power of the sovereign may lead us to suppose that whatever entities exist after the division are not sovereign at all. Given that an undivided, all-powerful sovereign is a preferable sort of political organization to an anarchic state of nature, we should opt for the former. This is the essence of Hobbes's argument. Nozick is a good foil; for he argues that the sole permissible functions of the state are to enforce contracts and protect its subjects. (Nozick, 1974) Beyond this point, the state is morally unjustified in doing anything further. Others believe that the state should not exist at all, or at least that there are no legitimate authorities.

Again, the important thing to note here is that the normative prescriptions we put to states, whether it be with respect to its size, limits, or constitution, are a product of constraint. Political philosophers argue that we ought to move from one state of affairs to another, given the inadequacy of the preceding state of affairs. Minecraft, by contrast, can always *be* adequate. We cannot prescribe how a state should look like in the game so much as one willingly and consciously participates in its construction. There is no *normative* pull. If we want a particular sort of state to arise in the game, we must make the conditions suitable for its realization. We would not be concerned with what we ought to do in order to realize high-level goods, e.g., maximizing the satisfaction of the players, setting up the right kind of state, or distributing resources in the most efficient manner; for the best way to do that, presumably, is to let everyone run amok and do whatever they wish. Because of the game's design as a sandbox, such ends are already built into the game. Minecraft is *already* a maximizing tool, since, *ceteris paribus*, it lets the player do whatever they want. Whatever political constraints there are appear to be artificial and scarcely normative. The place of political philosophy, then, if there is any, is in the realm of *institutional design*; of designing certain situations so as to achieve certain objectives and outcomes. Its place is not in offering us any novelties about what we ought to do in certain situations, since the game, at least politically, already gives us solutions.

[a] Aristotle used the term "democracy" to refer to the degenerate form of a constitution, in which the tyranny of the majority prevails. One may think of a "constitution" as something like a just, modern-day democracy. Additionally, for the three "just" versions of the possible configurations of the state, Aristotle posits an "unjust" mirror image of each of those forms; namely: *tyranny* for monarchy, *oligarchy* for aristocracy, and *democracy* for the constitution.

3.3 Ethics, generally considered

Now, in addition to this claim I also sought to claim something else; namely, that whatever normative prescriptions we *can* cash out of Minecraft servers, occur on the level of individuals rather than political communities. More specifically, normative ethics as applied to individuals still holds up in the presence of changes in institutional design. We have observed that a political community in Minecraft must in large part be designed so as to achieve certain specifications and objectives; for such communities would not otherwise have arisen. Normative relations between individuals, however, are scarcely so designed. Although changes in an external situation can enforce certain changes on the entirety of a community, the relations between individuals do not necessarily change character as a result; normative prescriptions between them still have the same character. For example, if it is generally permitted on a server for players to kill each other, this does not necessarily make it morally permissible for individuals to kill each other in turn. I may still have an obligation to my friend to refrain from killing them as far as killing them would cause them harm in-game (and in certain exceptional circumstances, in the real world). But the institutional design of the server has no bearing whatsoever on whether my killing my friend is permissible or impermissible. What institutional design can do is make certain actions more or less *acceptable*; for what matters in the case of institutional design is upholding the design itself, not necessarily maximizing a good. Hence breaking or following certain precepts may gain or lose one repute or respect. But this has no real normative import. If one desired to implement a monarchical system on a server, the question of whether the monarchy is, in fact, implemented can be pulled apart entirely from whether this arrangement benefits the players substantially. This is completely unlike the real world, wherein the maintenance of a state of affairs indeed has a direct bearing on the well-being of its participants.

To clarify: suppose that considerations of institutional design led us to desire the realization of a pattern, P, within a server. We may also suppose that the purpose of a server is to complete some objective, O, where O takes into account in some measure the well-being of the participants, or some other ethically relevant aspect of the participants' experience in the server. The claim is that O is not necessarily dependent on the mere realization, or process of realizing P. For the relation is actually inverted; depending on the objective of the server, the institutional design will reflect that objective. P, in fact, depends on O; and this dependence prefigures the relevant politico-philosophical precepts that account for what people ought to do once this pattern is established. Hence, any deviation from P can be accounted for by the fact that it may just reflect O more satisfactorily. Ethics *in general*, as it applies to the individual player, *can* figure in since that is precisely what determines the shape of O. It is important not to conflate such prescriptions with politico-philosophical ones. It still makes perfect logical sense, for instance, to talk about the aggregate utility of a group of agents without invoking the state or authority in general, and consequentialist and nonconsequentialist ethics without patterns of resource distribution.

These conclusions are intuitively absurd. However, I am not claiming that political philosophy is useless in Minecraft in general. Rather, I am claiming that it is not useful when we consider the study of human behavior in Minecraft servers specifically. Of course, were Minecraft like the real world to a high degree of accuracy, it would certainly be useful. But presumably the study of these pockets of human interaction is not the study of what individuals *ought* to do, but rather of *what* they do. What they ought to do can only be cashed out at the level of the individual, as far as they are charged with the presence of other players with whom they interact. But when it comes to the general design of the server in which they find themselves, any large-scale normative prescriptions that could hope to approximate anything that real-world political philosophy would offer vanish—and for the simple reason that one can theoretically realize whatever state of affairs they want within the game.

3.4 Concluding thoughts

What we find interesting about applying political philosophy to Minecraft is not, as our intuitions may tell us enticingly, the fact that we find moral prescriptions for what people should do under certain circumstances. Rather, what we find interesting is isolating certain facets of human behavior that we know to be present *already* and seeing them play out in real time without real-world consequences. Political philosophy cannot provide anything for the game for precisely this reason. When designing servers, or places where people coexist in general, one must inevitably come up against a form of the old Hegelian problem that a movement of a state of affairs is not necessary but *imposes* its necessity. In Minecraft servers, the ethical never becomes the political; for the political is imposed, not made.

3.5 Declarations

No conflict of interest and no AI use have been declared.

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Article 4

The removal of agency by server owners and reclaiming player power

Author: matcha_tea. Editor: retrooper. Single-blind peer reviewed.

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Abstract

Throughout the history of Minecraft servers, there is one system that has remained the same: leadership. At the top is the server's owner, the person who has the final say in any decision made; next are the server's admins, a group of people whom the owner trusts to act on their behalf; finally, there are the moderators, who enforce the server's rules and maintain conduct in the day-to-day running of the server. I call this the Traditional structure. This paper argues that this structure is fundamentally flawed by exploring the core function and purpose of a Minecraft server, which is to create *satisfaction* for players on the server. Two key terms are outlined: *agency* and *power*, which are important for understanding why the Traditional structure has and continues to fail players by examining the issue from the perspective of the Player. This paper considers the individual *player* and the lone decision-maker – the owner – as classes in a hierarchy to better understand the inter-class interactions, removing individual anomalies in behaviour and allowing readers to understand the problem at a higher level. Finally, this paper proposes a structure where Players (as a class) have no "need" for the Owner, as decisions would only be made by Players.

4.1 Introduction

The rigid Owner-Player hierarchy found in Traditional structures has created the most (monetarily) successful servers in the world (e.g., Hypixel, Mineplex, and Donut SMP). Both Raid Farms and Minecraft Bloodlines (MCB), the most studied and influential

servers in the field of Minecraft Server Theory (MST), have this rigid top-down structure of power. It can appear logical, even ideal, to have a few people at the top dictating the direction of the server and viewing players as numbers and statistics needing improvement.

Such hierarchical systems do not exist in isolation, but in the context of everything around their creators. Just like the most popular Minecraft servers, the most well-known real-life corporations also follow this kind of hierarchy – Amazon, Nestle, and Tesla to name a few.

I will argue in this paper that this hierarchical structure fails to achieve its goal, even when one thinks solely about higher and higher player counts. To understand why, one must also reframe one's thinking of the meaning of "success" for a server, which I argue should be in terms of *player satisfaction* instead of other numerical metrics. Following this, one must also understand that the Traditional structure fails to meet this goal and is also the reason why the vast majority of servers fail after the Two-Week Phase. I will discuss an alternative way of thinking about player satisfaction, and by extension, the success of a server. Moreover, having understood why the Traditional structure fails and how a different view should be adopted, I will discuss how the same structure deals with player suggestions and change. I will argue that the unilateral nature of the Owner means that Players are not satisfied, resulting in the eventual collapse in feelings of excitement for the server's potential. Finally, I will lay out a better structure of leadership which holds Player satisfaction at its core and would yield a more "successful" server.

In this paper, all mentions of "server" can be assumed to mean a *Survival Multiplayer (SMP)* server. An SMP is best defined in its components, which includes but is not limited to:

- Survival gamemode
- Multiplayer
- Focused on player-to-player interaction
- An open and expansive world for players to do as they wish

4.1.1 Use of "satisfaction" in this paper

The word *satisfaction* is used throughout this paper instead of *fun* as, ironically, what gives players *satisfaction* may not always be *fun*. Take the example of fighting the Ender Dragon. It is a difficult fight for the typical player, and one may die several times during the fight. This is by no means an activity that can objectively and easily be considered *fun*, but it brings about satisfaction in that the player continues to engage in the activity and has fun in the end. One can consider satisfaction to be fun in hindsight, where even if a player struggled during a difficult part of the game, as long as they came out of it for the better, they can think *in hindsight* that they *did* have fun.

4.2 Existing structures and hierarchies

The current mainstream leadership structure is roughly similar to the following:

> (In descending order of power)
>
> Owner > Admin > Moderator > Player

As explained in the next section, this structure is inefficient in achieving player satisfaction. However, we must first discuss *how* this structure works in practice and *why* it sometimes creates a successful server.

The Owner[a] holds the most power in a server and all decisions must be made with their approval. As they hold control of the Minecraft server (and usually also the Discord server that they might have), only *they* can make changes. Even if it is a decision that a majority of the leadership team (that is, the Admins and possibly the Moderators, together with the Owner) supports, only the Owner is able to actually install a mod or change the game difficulty, for example. This means they have complete autocratic control over all things, even if they are amicable and adhere to the majority rule. Thus, I think it is less pertinent to discuss the roles of the Admins and Moderators, as their power is ultimately given by the Owner.

If a real-life example can aid your understanding, take the United Kingdom – the King is the *de facto* head of state. Any law passed by both the Houses of Commons and Lords must be signed off by the King so that it may become the official law of the land. Without his rubber stamp, any law coming onto his desk will not be in effect, even if the entire country supports it.[b]

This is completely and undoubtedly dangerous. The high concentration of power, the selection of the next leader by the current leader, and the leader's failure to understand the experiences of ordinary people compound into a dangerous slope toward detachment from reality.

Why must an Owner, who is not elected, not chosen, and cannot be held accountable through any means (as they have the ultimate say and can completely disregard all dissent), control the entire server? Or really, in concrete terms – how does this ensure player satisfaction?

In a typical SMP server founded between friends, one of them will be the Owner who has likely initiated the idea, owning the physical server that the world is hosted on. Initially, the Owner may decide to ask their Players what kinds of mods and mechanics they would want present on the server. Thereafter, some players may request a change, and others may disagree with the requested change. The Owner acts as a mediator in these cases to make a quick decision based on their own opinion to move the conversation forwards, as they simply want to have fun with their friends. Here, maintaining a strict democratic decision-making process is not necessary as the goal is not to boost player

[a] *Owner* and other terms are capitalised as I am talking about the institution and the class of person, not specifically the person who embodies the role. This distinction is important as the things I talk about are *inherent* to the role and will not change depending on *who* is in that specific office.

[b] Parliament can, using specific laws, force legislation to be approved.

satisfaction and increase the regular player count; instead, the owner is part of a group of friends who use their server as a *medium* to interact and spend time together.

In other words, disagreements in terms of gameplay mechanics can be taken less seriously due to the server's goal, so having efficient and unilateral decision-making is good. Unilateral decision-making may also be more beneficial if all players already know each other before starting to play – which means discussion and compromise is more likely to be fruitful.

One may raise the issue that the server's goal might have been influenced or introduced by the players at the beginning of the server, which means that even if the owner unilaterally makes executive decisions, it still follows the intention set by the players at the beginning.

This is true; however, we must remember that goals and ideas shift over time. A player who suggests, for example, the Copper Rails mod to be installed on the server as they believe it will increase the uses of copper may later find, after using it for a while, that it actually decreases the incentive to mine for gold and iron. Here, their opinion on copper rails may change, but yet, they have no power to change the fact that the mod is installed.

In order for a server to have broad appeal, ensuring player satisfaction *and* increasing its regular player count, two things must be considered: player *agency* and player *power*.

I shall define *agency* as follows:

> Agency can be thought of as a player's inward feeling about whether they have the power to bring about change effectively on a server—which is a standard definition.

Power, however, has nuance to its definition in this context, which I shall define as follows:

> Typically, power is thought of as something which is direct, physical (or mental), or radical. However, power can come in many different ways. This can be power to speak up to a person with more power (e.g., the Owner), power to influence other players, power to enact practical change, and power to simply have one's opinion heard.

Let us first explore a simplified scenario involving a new player who initially enjoys a server but ultimately decides to leave.

First, the player is intrigued by something on the server. If we take the example of Raid Farms, this may be its famous wheat currency. They join the server and they are engaged with this mechanic. As time passes, they notice more things about the new mechanic that they previously hadn't, continuing to make them more and more enthused.

Then, the player inevitably finds a mechanic that they are not the most pleased with. Sticking with our example, the enchanting system has been a large topic of interest and discussion. At this point, the player feels a lot of agency to be *able* to do this as they have a positive view of the server overall, but not yet a lot of power in seeing real change or feedback.

Next, our newly joined but already dedicated player wants to change their new favourite server for the better. They make a suggestion in the server and find that many agree with them. Here, their feeling of agency continues to rise as their power to bring about change is affirmed. They also begin to feel more power as they seem to have invited many people who agree with them, rallying for the change.

The Owner notices this, agrees, and listens to their feedback. We see the peak of both agency and power here: agency is felt by those who feel strongly about this issue when the highest authority on the server affirms that their concerns are valid, and power is felt because they managed to influence this person, who is seen as a role model.

Finally, when the change is implemented, the player might feel unsatisfied, especially if the implementation does not meet their expectations. The change may not have been implemented perfectly, or it may even just require one or two more tweaks. However, at this point, the player's agency is completely shattered as they feel that they are not heard, and thus, did not bring about the change they desired.

Not all players decide to leave immediately after this, but it is very likely that some might. We should also remember that our dedicated new joiner would not leave at this point, as they feel a sense of *loyalty* to the server, but the vast majority of players view a server as a product to be consumed, not an institution or organisation deserving protection, advancement, and dedication.[a]

In terms of looking at agency and power for player satisfaction, the breaking point occurred when the Owner, being this perceived bastion of power and being the ultimate decision-maker, went against the wishes of the players. The players' individual belief that the Owner knows what is best for the server, and what steps to take in order to reach their goal, has been shattered as they *themselves* put the Owner on this pedestal.

One may argue that the fault is not in having an Owner but in the beliefs of the Players. However, this ignores the context in which the Players exist – one where the Owner places themselves in this position of power and status, almost asking to be admired for their apparent wisdom. Players simply follow this expectation that the Owner must be looked up to – creating the situation we find ourselves in.

4.3 Pleasing the players

Now that we've discussed what typical mainstream servers have as their hierarchy of power, and the feelings of agency and power individual players have, we shall shift focus to the Players as a group.

Say that you are the owner of a server – how do you balance your own vision for the server from before it started with the assumed visions of the players? How can you make sure the decisions demanded by the players are recognised without allowing them to make choices that (in your view) harm the server? Is it possible to increase the popularity of your server without assimilating with the ever-growing number of servers who all have one, stubborn, goal in their mind – increasing player count?

[a] I recognise that this is an unsupported claim.

In order to answer these questions, you must understand the two weights in play in any multiplayer server – the view of the players and the view of the server owner.[a] If the two views are visualised as a two-circle Venn diagram, the area of their intersection can be thought of as the amount of flexibility an owner has in making decisions – how much of their own circle they can pick ideas out of. This intersection also represents the views that both the Owner and the Players have in common.

However, these are *weights*, meaning that they also possess another property – their physical mass – or, how important they are perceived to be. This perception can be held by the server owner regarding players, meaning how much of the players' opinions are taken into account when deciding server mechanics, for example. This can also be a perception held by the players themselves – whether they feel they have a voice in making decisions.

Four possible situations arise from these two factors which I shall deal with independently:

1. Large intersection of views[b] + High weight of player opinion
2. Large intersection of views + Low weight of player opinion
3. Low intersection of views + High weight of player opinion
4. Low intersection of views + Low weight of player opinion

The first case is the optimal case in a hierarchical server – the server owner is satisfied that their direction for the server lines up with their player base's opinion, and they are open to taking the players' views in consideration when making decisions.

One may argue that the second term is a direct cause of the first term. In other words, because the owner has a large number of views in common with their players, it is much easier for the owner to accept them as peers. Although this view seems straightforward and natural, the two terms are completely independent from each other. Take the example of a server owner whose direction for their server is popular among the player base but who does not actively listen to them, instead making decisions independently – it is simply coincidental that the owner's actions align with the players' wants.

The above situation would be representative of the second case – a lot in common, but the owner acts independently. It is also important to note that these terms are fluid – an owner who has a lot in common with their players at the establishment of the server may not hold the same values or vision for the server after a few months of operation; similarly, an owner who is receptive to feedback at the start may later find their player base acting rashly, and thus, decrease the weight on player opinion when making decisions.

The third case is of a humble and open owner – although their vision is unaligned with their players', they are still open to feedback and advice. These owners listen to

[a] In some servers, this may also be the view of the admins, or even moderators. In any case, I refer to the person, or group of people, who have power to make decisions about the server.

[b] That is, of the server owner and the players.

their players attentively and are usually the ones who are thought of most highly by the players and considered "one of the people", creating an equal environment where all views are respected.

One may argue here that the third case is the optimum. Firstly, despite the differences in opinion, the owner continues to take the players' perspectives into account; thus, this must be the case where the most respect is given – even more than the first case, as the respect in that case may be fragile. Further, the owner being amicable with their player base, and the players being amicable with the owner, must mean that a more positive community is built.

To explain why both arguments fail – or why both positions remain rather *inefficient* for the goal of player satisfaction – we must consider them in relation to the goal of a server.

What is the purpose of a Minecraft server? Or even, what *is* a Minecraft server?

I will define a server (that is, not *only* an SMP, e.g., anarchy, geopol) for the purposes of the following sections as follows:

> A multiplayer environment where people involved in the environment, be it as a moderator or player, work towards a goal that they individually have. This may be a shared goal, a formally recognised and rigid goal, or even an informal goal such as "fun". An "environment" could refer to a Survival world with the Nether and End locked, or a Creative server with building plots.

Ultimately, servers have a loose goal – and for an SMP, which this paper deals with – this is *fun*. The exact definition of fun is not important here, but the fact that this subjective goal remains desired is of importance.[a]

There are a few things that must be understood to realise the flawed nature of one figure ruling over an entire server.

Firstly, recognise that *players* play on a server. Even if the owner plays on the server, they can also be thought of as a player. The subjective goal of fun needs to be agreed upon by the majority of the players in order to maximise the amount of fun that any particular individual may have. This is usually done through discussion between players either within the server environment itself (in-game) or through external forums, such as Discord.

Secondly, understand that the players *themselves* will know best about what *they* want. Even when given a private, honest space to share their opinions, some players will still feel anxious about dissenting against the Owner, whom they perceive as "all-knowing".

Further, no amount of oversight or observation by the owner may be able to represent *all* player opinions. Even if the owner plays on the server regularly and engages with the community as a normal player, they will still have a skewed or biased view of the server. There is also the question of differential treatment by players towards the owner

[a]Note that *fun* and *satisfaction* are not the same idea. *Fun* is a broad and generally undefined word used to describe a "vibe" players get when they are feeling *satisfied* on a server. Because it is unspecific and relating to an *emotion*, I separate these.

when they are playing, which will also exaggerate the positive aspects of the players and diminish the negative ones.

One can argue that if the owner plays on an "alt account", they will be able to get a true experience on the server; however, this will also produce a biased result depending on the owner's own play style, influencing whom they interact with.

Thirdly, many players often put forward suggestions for changing a server by discussing them among themselves, then bringing those suggestions forward to the owner – usually through more influential or well-known players who may have sway over the owner. However, this is an inefficient way of creating change.

Fourthly, even if the owner always does approve of all suggestions, there may be disagreement in the implementation of the suggestions. An owner will always have a skewed view of their server, as mentioned above, due to their status and role in the power hierarchy. This may have the effect of creating more harm than good, as the players could feel that their desires are not being fulfilled – but at the same time, the owner can develop a perception that their work is not being valued and that implementing player suggestions is a waste of time.[a] Consequently, this creates a negative feedback loop that causes the area of intersection between the Owner and the Players to shrink, leading to the opinion of the Players being given less weight, until the point where the two classes are completely polarised and players begin to leave.

Having considered these points, one can still find a commonality between them – which is that all decisions could be made by the owner. One may suggest that this results in quick, efficient decision-making and less bureaucracy, allowing players to experience server changes more quickly and accelerating the feedback loop.[b] This may also mean that players have a higher likelihood (due to how frequently opportunities to show agency arise) of feeling satisfaction. All processes have trade-offs, and this example is one that we must deal with.

In order to please players and restore their power, inefficiency is a necessary evil. As we've established, only players know best what they want in a server, and any other person or group of people making decisions *for* them in the name of "knowing better" is *more* inefficient as it will not deliver a satisfactory result and will require more iterations of the feedback loop – this is compared to the often tedious and long-drawn nature of discussion and collective decision making, but it almost always guarantees a more satisfactory result.

The fact that players collectively make these decisions also means that discussions can be more civil as every person has equal amounts of power, sharing a unifying goal that is constructive – compared to the unifying, but unhelpfully critical, goal that players may have against the owner.

One could construct a strong argument that setting up a new server and establishing new leadership can provide an entirely clean slate for a more stable form of leadership.

[a] Of course, not every owner will think the same. However, for the purposes of this paper, I shall use a generalisation of the worst-case-scenario where applicable.

[b] The feedback loop is the following: problem → solution identified → change → player feedback → (repeat)

One fault in this argument is that the players' emotional attachment to the world remains overlooked. This means a brand-new world must be created. Players must re-establish relationships, create new cultural landmarks, and invent new in-jokes about the server. This process is physically exhausting, mentally exhausting, and most importantly: it decreases satisfaction monumentally.

Further, I believe the revolution (so to say) of the Players against the Owner can deliver even more satisfaction than resetting everything. Server cultures stay in place, relationships remain stable (if not reinforced), and the world stays the same. If, eventually, the Players do overthrow the Owner, a new vibrant culture of daily discussion – which players know will at least not be a waste of time – can drive players' motivation to play and participate on the server. This is in contrast to there being an issue on a server with a Traditional structure, where a player may try to create change before ultimately giving up.

4.4 Reclaiming player power

The players' power can, and must be, *reclaimed*. The system of operating a server where this is achieved is the *Co-operative* system.

Due to the already established monopoly of the Owner over the Players, it is essential that the Players unite against the Owner. There must be no doubt between players that what they are against is an (almost) immovable force who has control over *their* server and *their* community. The Players must realise that as long as they have an owner, their feelings of agency will be capped at a certain level due to the presence of an immovable obstacle to gaining ultimate collective power.

This is where *celebrity players* come in – these people have the most agency (as they already know that they are popular amongst other players), and the most power (as they are also recognised *personally* by the owner), which allows them to influence both the classes effectively. The influence they perform leads to increased feelings of agency, which in turn also boosts their own satisfaction – which can lead to a positive feedback loop, allowing them to influence the owner even more.

I envision this to be a long, tedious, and very difficult process: when you try to dispel the myth of "efficiency" and "wisdom" of the Owner to a recipient who has only ever known the status-quo, you will meet great resistance. However, once much of the Players have been educated about these matters, they should constantly and without hesitation repeat the same, commonly agreed-upon message of disapproval to show their unity against the Owner. The Players shall force the Owner to be removed and immediately set up concrete infrastructure within the Discord server (or other means of communication) to establish the following as a minimum:[a]

1. An open, free, and respectful space for debate and discussion
2. Direct voting on server mechanics, which can be initiated by any player

[a]Please keep in mind that this should not be taken as a fully planned out manifesto – this paper simply lays the foundation for its necessity.

3. An Executive Council chosen by lottery to implement approved changes

The first is essential for any Player-owned server, as the basis of the entire concept is for players to be able to discuss amongst themselves and enact change directly to other members of the same class; a safe space for all players to participate in this process is absolutely necessary. This space must be inclusive of all and do its best to give equal weight and time to all voices, no matter how famous, influential, or veteran. However, at the same time, members of the Executive Council must not be able to participate in debate, and they must be politically neutral because of their role, which requires them to be disinterested and unbiased parties whose job is simply to *carry out* the agreed-upon wishes of the Players.

This will also cement the fact that agency and satisfaction are the primary goals of a co-operative server. If players feel that they are able to drive change (and if they truly can drive change), they will feel like they have *agency*. Similarly, if there is a lower barrier to enjoying oneself on the server, satisfaction will come about more easily.

The second of the three-legged stool allows for the results of these debates to be carried out. Direct voting means that every player's vote is equal and meaningful. Decisions by referendum also avoid the problem that ultimately rises from using a representative system, which gives certain players an elevated position, mimicking the Owner. The latter part of this point enshrines the equal right and power of every player to be able to create change. In terms of agency and power, this reaffirms both.

This right also creates opportunities for abuse and trolling, as a newly joined troll has the exact same power as a two-year veteran. However, this right is essential to maintain a "no exceptions" culture when it comes to having the right to say something is wrong, and to change it, starting from oneself. To address this risk, a simple majority vote could be conducted, serving as a preliminary check before continuing to debate a proposed issue or solution.

The final point ensures that the debates held were not pointless and that a team of regular players – not a dictatorial entity like the Owner – will carry out the practical steps needed implement a new change. This Executive Council is chosen by lottery, meaning that it is not disproportionately filled with self-sorting players who may have a certain bias or obsession with the server's operations, making them *interested* parties and likely ineffective at being unbiased when carrying out the necessary, practical work. This also serves as a safeguard against corruption, as the players who bring a proposal to the Council cannot influence it without knowing *who* is on the Council.

A random chance of being on the Council also means that a culture of equality is established. Because serving on it is normalised, players begin to feel like part of a political culture where everyone *is* truly *seen* and *treated* as equal.

4.5 Caveat for this system

It is important to note that, just like many server proposals, one that focuses on restoring agency and power may not always be the best for the players. Take the example of a

Vanilla UHC server – there are a set of rules, some mods, and everything else is set in stone. Not only are the Players' opinions not heard or cared about, but they are not given any weight either. The established culture within the server is that "it is what it is", and making changes is irrelevant. The prevailing view is that a server built on survival, competition, PvP, and defending your base does not require players to get involved with *how* it is managed.

Although total disregard for player feedback remains rare, servers with concrete and specific goals face a significant challenge. It is difficult to justify introducing player-led decision-making on these servers, even regarding peripheral issues where the players might actually make better decisions.

4.6 Conclusion

In this paper, we've discussed existing hierarchical structures of leadership, player satisfaction regarding agency and power, and the intersections of Player and Owner views. We also assessed how much weight these views hold for the Owner and provided a template for how Players can take back ownership of their servers.

4.7 Acknowledgements

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4.8 Declarations

No conflict of interest and no AI use have been declared.